

Lounge Lizard

Two slices of Mumbai life come together in a blogger's first novel

| By Geeta Doctor |



MY FRIEND SANCHO
by AMIT VARMA
Hachette India
Price: Rs 195
Pages: 218

A bir Ganguly, free spirit, tabloid journalist, saviour of distressed females living in outer Mumbai, cavorts through the pages of Amit Varma's first novel. You may ask who is Amit Varma? Check out his blog India Uncut. It's mentioned several times in the book by Abir, who seems to be something of a fan, so do forgive me if I have already begun to confuse Amit-Abir and

think of them as Ambir, a semi-fictional creature who has parlayed his success as a blogger into a more permanent form.

In blogland, Amit is something of a don. In another era, he would have been described as a lively toff, a purveyor of one-liners that could pass for humour in case you imagine that taking

a potshot at Shob-ahh! De's penchant for adding extra alphabets to her name is wildly funny. Should Abir be given to self-reflection, he would confess straight off: "Amit c'est moi". Certainly, given the number of times Abir-Amit stares into the camera, you know the hand-held camcorder variety in which the photographer turns the lens onto himself, or herself, and speaks directly to the viewer, you get the feeling that he is talking to himself, by himself and for himself. And when he is not talking to himself, he is in close consultation with his 'organ' as he calls it—would this be a mouth organ, Amit? Or with his pillow that he hugs instead of the girl—Muneeza is her name, by the way—or her bra as it hangs in the bathroom when she chastely decides to take up his offer to spend the night in his apartment, or most importantly with his friendly house-lizard. He also speaks to shop mannequins as they stare at him through the glass front of a store, which is not very surprising because aside from his claustrophobic little flat, he spends most of his time describing how to take a girl out for a cup of coffee in one of Mumbai's well-known malls. We shall not actually name the place, since already Ambir tends to tag the cafes and shops that he visits as if he were a brand ambassador for them.

Bloggers presume that everything they say and do, but most importantly "think", is of the top, completely over the top, routinely and verbosely over the top interest to anyone out there across the ether. They also appear to lose the thread, the point, the er...umm...ah so... point, as Ambir might say, since digressions are the very essence of the blogger's wit.

Despite all that, there is something sweet about Ambir's debut. He's taken two disparate slices of the ordinary Mumbaikar's life—that of a policeman named Vallabh Thombre and his casual victim Mohammed Iqbal—and placed them side by side for the reader to contemplate, while throwing in complications of a communal kind with his romance with Muneeza, who is also called Sancho. For further details read, or google, Don Quixote. There's a brief walk-in part for a formidable Mother, the Bengali kind. All things considered however, it's the lizard that gets my vote. It even looks unbearably sexy on the cover.



SAURABH SINGH



THE INDIANS: INTERESTING ASPECTS, EXTRAORDINARY FACETS

by SUMANT BATRA
Treepie
Price: Rs 8,500
Pages: 249

Casts a roving eye through the country and showcases the extraordinary spirit of the Indians.



ANNAM BRAHMA: ORGANIC FOOD IN INDIA

Compiled and edited by ANJALI PATHAK
Pilgrims
Price: Rs 650
Pages: 402

A handy reference for all who are engaged or interested in organic food and farming in India.



SUFISM: THE HEART OF ISLAM

by SADIA DEHLVI
HarperCollins India
Price: Rs 695
Pages: 352

Proves that Sufism is the continuity of a thought process that links Muslims to their religious predecessors, all the way to Prophet Muhammad.